

Why Trees are important

The beauty of trees is in their size, shape, and texture, and in the details of leaves, flowers, fruits, and bark. They change with the seasons, and we can enjoy watching them grow over our lifetimes and know that they will be there after us. Children grow up playing in and around trees, and can watch them grow as they grow. Because they are bigger than we are/ and live longer, trees can be landmarks in space and time, giving us a sense of continuity, a connection with the past and the future. For many people trees give a sense of proportion, putting day-to-day worries into perspective.

Trees are good for our health, and the health of the planet.

Environmental protection - trees can:

- slow down wind - plants grow better, heating bills go down
- give shade and protection against ultraviolet radiation (more is being let through because of ozone depletion) and skin cancer
- absorb pollution
- absorb carbon dioxide and slow down global climate change
- stabilize banks
- muffle noise

Sustainable crops - trees can provide us with:

- timber and other craft materials
- fuel - wood can be burnt sustainably in cleanburn woodburning stoves in houses, larger buildings, and in small power stations
- food - fruit and nuts
- Other products such as medicines and dyes (e.g. Aspirin is derived from willow bark)

Wildlife habitats:

- trees can give shelter and food for innumerable species of animals and plants
- trees are especially important if they form "green corridors" connecting habitats up with each other and with the countryside beyond
- some trees are wildlife in their own right, if they are native to Britain and indigenous to the place they are planted, and made their own way here after the last ice age without human help.

“Trees are big and old and beautiful”

1) Trees Produce Oxygen

Let's face it; we could not exist as we do if there were no trees. A mature leafy tree produces as much oxygen in a season as 10 people inhale in a year. What many people don't realize is the forest also acts as a giant filter that cleans the air we breath.

2) Trees Clean the Soil

The term phoremediation is a fancy word for the absorption of dangerous chemicals and other pollutants that have entered the soil. Trees can either store harmful pollutants or actually change the pollutant into less harmful forms. Trees filter sewage and farm chemicals, reduce the effects of animal wastes, clean roadside spills and clean water runoff into streams.

3) Trees Control Noise Pollution

Trees muffle urban noise almost as effectively as stone walls. Trees, planted at strategic points in a neighborhood or around your house, can abate major noises from freeways and airports.

4) Trees Slow Storm Water Runoff

Flash flooding can be dramatically reduced by a forest or by planting trees. One Colorado blue spruce, either planted-or growing wild, can intercept more than 1000 gallons of water annually when fully grown. Underground water-holding aquifers are recharged with this slowing down of water runoff.

5) Trees Are Carbon Sinks

To produce its food, a tree absorbs and locks away carbon dioxide in the wood, roots and leaves. Carbon dioxide is a global warming suspect. A forest is a carbon storage area or a "sink" that can lock up as much carbon as it produces. This locking-up process "stores" carbon as wood and not as an available "greenhouse" gas.

6) Trees Clean the Air

Trees help cleanse the air by intercepting airborne particles, reducing heat, and absorbing such pollutants as carbon monoxide, sulfur dioxide, and nitrogen dioxide. Trees remove this air pollution by lowering air temperature, through respiration, and by retaining particulates.

7) Trees Shade and Cool

Shade resulting in cooling is what a tree is best known for. Shade from trees reduces the need for air conditioning in summer. In winter, trees break the force of winter winds, lowering heating costs. Studies have shown-that parts of cities without cooling shade from trees can literally be "heat islands" with temperatures as much as 12 degrees Fahrenheit higher than surrounding areas.

8) Trees Act as Windbreaks

During windy and cold seasons, trees located on the windward side act as windbreaks. A windbreak can lower home heating bills up to 30% and have a significant effect on reducing snowdrifts. A reduction in wind can also reduce the drying effect on soil and vegetation behind the windbreak and help keep precious topsoil in place.

9) Trees Fight Soil Erosion

Erosion control has always started with tree and grass planting projects. Tree roots bind the soil and their leaves break the force of wind and rain on soil. Trees fight soil erosion, conserve rainwater and reduce water runoff and sediment deposit after storms.